for the security forces, while the Malayalis and Ceylonese Tamilians from the southern rim migrated for clerical and administrative positions. Finally, as previously noted, the Chettiars and other merchants migrated to set up trading and moneylending posts. By the 1940s, Indians comprised around a sixth of Malaya's population, gradually falling to less than a tenth by the end of the 20th century as the labour pipeline was shut down in the 1950s due to restrictive immigration policies. The latter two migrant groups did well for themselves but the plantation or ex-plantation workforce that comprised the majority of the 2-million-strong Indian diaspora continued to lag at the bottom of the social and economic pyramid.

There were several reasons for this predicament. The Malay world was different from Burma because of a sizable Chinese immigrant population and colonial policies that were tuned towards creating divisions between the Indian, Chinese and indigenous Malay population, now referred to as the *bumiputera*s, literally the 'sons of the soil'. If caste had given way to race in Trinidad, in Malaysia it moved to consolidate on ethnicity, sowing the seeds of ethnic tension that persist till date.[19] Previously, plantation life involved a high degree of social and geographic exclusion which led to strengthening of the Indian or Tamil group identity, but over the 20th century this failed to corner economic gains because of low representation in business and politics. The medium of education in the schools for plantation workers was Tamil, which did little to foster integration or equip workers with skills demanded by the global economy. Further, the takeover of plantations by the state after independence in 1957, and enforcement of nativist employment policies, displaced many Indians to live in urban slums and in greater poverty.

A completely different Indian world exists right opposite the Johor Strait that separates Malaysia and Singapore. In Singapore, the Indian diaspora of over half a million comprises around 10 per cent of the local population, and is more diverse and economically successful than in Malaysia. The Indian connection with Singapore began right from its formative stage. Modern Singapore was founded by Thomas Stamford Raffles (1781–1826) in 1819 with the assistance of Bhojpuri-speaking soldiers serving in the